

**MOUNT KENYA UNIVERSITY
SCHOOL OF EDUCATION**

**ASSESSING TEACHERS' COMPETENCE AND ITS INFLUENCE ON THE
EFFECTIVE IMPLEMENTATION OF THE COMPETENCY-BASED
CURRICULUM IN PUBLIC PRIMARY SCHOOLS IN HABASWEIN SUB-
COUNTY, WAJIR COUNTY, KENYA**

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A Research Proposal Submitted to the School of Education in Partial Fulfilment of the
Requirements for the Award of the Degree of Master of Education (Curriculum
Studies) of Mount Kenya University

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DECLARATION

This research proposal is my original work and has not been presented for the award of a degree or for any other award in any other university.

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Supervisors' Approval

This research proposal has been submitted for examination with our approval as the university supervisors.

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School of Education, Mount Kenya University

Signature: _____ Date: _____

DEDICATION

To my family, who quietly took on extra load so that I could study, and to the teachers of Habaswein, who keep showing up for their learners even when conditions make it hard.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

First, I thank God for good health and for bringing me this far. I owe a lot to my supervisors, who read my drafts patiently and told me plainly where the argument was weak; the proposal is better because of them. My thanks also go to the lecturers and staff of the School of Education at Mount Kenya University, and to my classmates, with whom I shared many late nights and deadlines. A number of head teachers and teachers in Habaswein spoke to me informally about their work while I was still shaping this topic. Listening to them is what persuaded me that the study was worth doing. Lastly, I thank my family for their support throughout.

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ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

Abbreviation	Meaning
ASAL	Arid and Semi-Arid Lands
BOM	Board of Management
CBAM	Concerns-Based Adoption Model
CBC	Competency-Based Curriculum
CBE	Competency-Based Education
CSO	Curriculum Support Officer
CVI	Content Validity Index
ICT	Information and Communication Technology
KICD	Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development
KNBS	Kenya National Bureau of Statistics
KNEC	Kenya National Examinations Council
KPSEA	Kenya Primary School Education Assessment
MKU	Mount Kenya University
MoE	Ministry of Education
NACOSTI	National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation
PCIs	Pertinent and Contemporary Issues
PCK	Pedagogical Content Knowledge
PWPER	Presidential Working Party on Education Reform
SBA	School-Based Assessment
SPSS	Statistical Package for the Social Sciences
TPD	Teacher Professional Development
TSC	Teachers Service Commission

OPERATIONAL DEFINITION OF TERMS

Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC): The curriculum Kenya began rolling out in 2017 under the Basic Education Curriculum Framework. Rather than stressing how much content learners can remember, it stresses what they are able to do with what they learn. The Ministry of Education now calls it Competency-Based Education (CBE), and in this proposal the two names mean the same thing.

Teacher competence: The knowledge, skills and attitudes a teacher needs in order to deliver the CBC the way it was designed. Here it is measured through two parts: the teacher's knowledge and understanding of the CBC, and the teacher's pedagogical competence.

Knowledge and understanding of CBC: The extent to which a teacher understands the philosophy and goals of the CBC, its core competencies and values, the pertinent and contemporary issues, and the curriculum designs.

Pedagogical competence: A teacher's ability to plan and teach learner-centred lessons, assess learners as teaching goes on, keep assessment records and portfolios, and use the resources available, ICT included.

Effective implementation of CBC: How closely classroom practice matches what the curriculum designs expect. It is judged by learner engagement, the integration of core competencies and values, continuous assessment, parental involvement and whether the curriculum designs are covered on time.

Factors affecting teacher competence: Conditions inside and around the school that help or hinder teachers in gaining and using CBC competence, for example training, resources, workload, class size, instructional support and insecurity.

Public primary school: A government school in Habaswein Sub-County that offers Grades 1 to 6 under the CBC and whose teachers are employed either by the TSC or by the Board of Management.

Marginalised area: An area that gets fewer services and records weaker education indicators than the national average, mainly because it is remote, dry, thinly populated or insecure. Habaswein Sub-County is one such area.

ABSTRACT

Kenya moved from the 8-4-4 system to the Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC) hoping that learners would leave school able to think for themselves, solve problems and use what they have learnt. How far this happens depends largely on the classroom

teacher. Studies done in different parts of the country show that many teachers still find CBC lesson planning, learner-centred teaching and competency-based assessment difficult. In remote and arid areas, where fewer teachers are reached by training and staff turnover is high, the difficulties are probably greater. Even so, most of the available evidence comes from Nairobi, central and western Kenya, and hardly any from the north-east. This study will assess teachers' competence and its influence on the effective implementation of the CBC in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County. It will assess teachers' knowledge and understanding of CBC principles and practice, analyse their pedagogical competence, identify the factors that affect their competence and establish how competence relates to effective implementation. The Concerns-Based Adoption Model and Shulman's theory of Pedagogical Content Knowledge will guide the study. A descriptive survey design combining quantitative and qualitative data will be used. The target population is 368 teachers and 46 head teachers in 46 public primary schools. A sample of 192 teachers will be drawn using Yamane's formula and proportionate stratified random sampling, while 14 head teachers will be picked purposively. Data will be collected using a teacher questionnaire, a head teacher interview guide, a classroom observation checklist and a document analysis guide, all of which will first be piloted in Wajir South Sub-County. SPSS will be used to run descriptive statistics, Pearson's correlation and regression on the quantitative data, and the qualitative data will be analysed thematically. It is hoped that the findings will help the Ministry of Education, the Teachers Service Commission, teacher training institutions and head teachers to support teachers in marginalised areas more effectively.

Key words: teacher competence, Competency-Based Curriculum, pedagogical competence, curriculum implementation, marginalised areas, Habaswein

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background to the Study

In many countries, education systems are slowly moving away from curricula that focus on covering content and passing examinations. The new focus is on competencies, meaning what learners can actually do with the knowledge, skills and values they acquire. Behind this shift is a real concern: plenty of young people complete school with good grades yet struggle to solve practical problems, work in teams or continue learning on their own. Competency-based approaches try to address this by changing classroom practice. The teacher talks less and designs more activities in which learners do the thinking, and learners are assessed throughout the year instead of mainly through a final examination.

In practice, this kind of change is difficult, and most of the burden falls on teachers. Hall and Hord (2020) argue that a curriculum reform succeeds or fails in the classroom, and that teachers pass through fairly predictable stages of concern before they become comfortable with something new. When they are pushed through these stages too quickly, the reform is adopted on paper while the old ways of teaching carry on. Rwanda is a useful example. The country introduced a competence-based curriculum in 2015, yet eight years later Nsengimana et al. (2023) found that many science teachers only partly understood what “competence” meant, and several of them still relied on teacher-centred methods. Closer to home, Kidega et al. (2024) reported that teachers in Gulu City, Uganda, were handling classes of about 66 learners with poor facilities and very little training. Under those conditions, learner-centred teaching was hard to sustain.

Kenya started its own reform in 2017, when the Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD) introduced the CBC under the Basic Education Curriculum Framework (KICD, 2017). Sessional Paper No. 1 of 2019 later anchored the reform in policy (Ministry of Education [MoE], 2019). The curriculum seeks to produce “engaged, empowered and ethical citizens” through seven core competencies, including communication and collaboration, critical thinking and problem solving, creativity and imagination, and digital literacy. In 2022 the first CBC cohort sat the Kenya Primary School Education Assessment (KPSEA). A year later the Presidential Working Party on Education Reform (PWPER) recommended that the reform should continue, but with fewer learning areas and a retooling programme for teachers who had trained before the CBC was introduced (PWPER, 2023). The Ministry has since

adopted the name Competency-Based Education (CBE), although what is expected of teachers has not changed.

What is expected is a lot. A CBC teacher has to understand the thinking behind the reform and plan lessons around specific learning outcomes and key inquiry questions. The same teacher must weave values and pertinent and contemporary issues into lessons, use learner-centred methods, and assess learners through observation, projects, portfolios and other school-based tools (Mwang'ombe, 2021). Keter and Wabuke (2025) see teacher preparedness as the backbone of the reform. Akala (2021) goes further and describes teachers as “the heartbeat” of the innovation, while pointing out that the early rollout was hurried and poorly resourced. Research across Kenya shows that teachers’ understanding varies a great deal. In Bomet East, Momanyi and Rop (2019) found that early grade teachers had only a vague idea of what the CBC required. Mutua and Waweru (2023) linked weak implementation in Machakos County to a shortage of learning materials and high teacher–pupil ratios. In Kinangop, Karua et al. (2025) observed that many teachers were familiar with CBC terms but had difficulty matching their teaching to them. An evaluation by the African Population and Health Research Center (APHRC, 2022) also found that truly learner-centred lessons were still the exception rather than the rule.

If teachers in fairly well-served counties are finding the CBC hard, then the arid north-east needs particular attention. Wajir County is part of Kenya’s Arid and Semi-Arid Lands, where long distances, repeated droughts and pastoral movement have kept education indicators below the national average for many years. Habaswein Sub-County lies in the south-west of the county and had about 174,000 residents at the 2019 census (Kenya National Bureau of Statistics [KNBS], 2019). Its schools serve both settled and pastoralist families, many of whom live in scattered settlements far apart from one another. Insecurity has added to the problem since 2023. After threats and attacks linked to al-Shabaab, many non-local teachers asked to be transferred out of Wajir, Mandera and Garissa, and the TSC had to hire contract teachers to cover the shortfall (The Star, 2024). Writing about northern Kenya, Hussein (2023) noted that CBC implementation in the region was slowed by poor training, few resources and difficulty in adjusting to the new teaching methods.

From the above, it appears that the success of the CBC depends to a large extent on teacher competence, and that this competence is under particular pressure in places like Habaswein. However, there is little local evidence on how competent teachers in the sub-county are, what holds them back and how much this affects the way the CBC is delivered. The present study intends to provide that evidence.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

By now, every public primary school in Kenya is expected to have teachers who understand the CBC, plan lessons around learning outcomes, use learner-centred methods and assess learners continuously. If this were happening, children would finish Grade 6 with the competencies the curriculum promises. Both the Basic Education Curriculum Framework (KICD, 2017) and the PWPER (2023) report assume this is the case. Almost ten years into the rollout, however, the situation on the ground is different. Studies from several counties report that many teachers are still unsure of what the CBC requires, find competency-based assessment confusing and continue to teach in the old teacher-centred way (Cheruiyot, 2024; Karua et al., 2025; Mutua & Waweru, 2023). The short cascade trainings offered so far have not changed classroom practice enough (Awiti, 2023; Kailo & Njagi, 2025).

The problem is probably worse in Habaswein Sub-County. Teachers there work in remote schools with few instructional materials, carry heavy workloads and seldom get chances for professional development. When many non-local teachers left after 2023, some schools were left with newly hired or contract teachers who may have received little CBC training (The Star, 2024). If teachers lack competence in the CBC, learners miss the practical, skills-based learning the curriculum was meant to offer, and the gap between marginalised and better-served regions is likely to grow. Yet nearly all the research on teacher competence and the CBC has been done in Nairobi, Machakos, Meru, Bomet, Nyandarua and western Kenya. Very little is known about the level of teacher competence in Habaswein, what shapes it, or how it relates to CBC implementation (APHRC, 2022; Hussein, 2023). Without such evidence, efforts to support teachers in the sub-county are likely to remain general and poorly targeted. It is against this background that this study seeks to assess teachers' competence and its influence on the effective implementation of the CBC in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.

1.3 Purpose of the Study

This study aims to assess how competent teachers in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County, are in handling the Competency-Based Curriculum, and to find out how their competence affects the way the curriculum is implemented. The findings will then be used to suggest practical ways of building teachers' capacity in marginalised areas.

1.4 Research Objectives

1.4.1 General Objective

To assess teachers' competence and its influence on the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County, Kenya.

1.4.2 Specific Objectives

The study will be guided by the following specific objectives:

- i. To assess teachers' knowledge and understanding of the principles and practice of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.
- ii. To analyse the level of teachers' pedagogical competence in implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.
- iii. To identify the factors affecting teachers' competence in implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.
- iv. To establish the relationship between teachers' competence and the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.

1.5 Research Questions

The study will seek to answer the following questions:

- i. How well do teachers in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County understand the principles and practice of the Competency-Based Curriculum?
- ii. What is the level of teachers' pedagogical competence in implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County?
- iii. What factors affect teachers' competence in implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County?
- iv. What is the relationship between teachers' competence and the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County?

1.6 Research Hypothesis

The fourth objective will be tested using the following null hypothesis at the 0.05 level of significance:

H₀₁: There is no statistically significant relationship between teachers' competence and the effective implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County.

1.7 Justification of the Study

There are three main reasons why this study is needed now. To begin with, the first CBC cohorts have already moved through primary school into junior school, and the PWPER (2023) has asked for teachers to be retooled. Planning that retooling requires knowing where teachers currently stand, particularly in regions that national samples usually leave out. Secondly, since 2023 the north-east has experienced an unusual staffing upheaval. Many experienced non-local teachers left and were replaced by new or contract teachers (The Star, 2024), which has most likely changed the competence profile of the teaching force in ways earlier studies did not capture. Thirdly, the few studies done in northern Kenya (Hussein, 2023) are small and mainly descriptive, and none of them tested the link between teacher competence and implementation in Habaswein. A study focused on the sub-county will help to close this gap and give policy makers clearer guidance than broad remarks about “challenges in marginalised areas”.

1.8 Significance of the Study

The findings are expected to be useful to several groups:

- **The Ministry of Education and the TSC** could use the findings when designing retooling and in-service programmes for teachers in arid and remote areas, and when planning staffing and hardship incentives.
- **The Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development** may find the results useful in revising curriculum support materials and training content to suit low-resource schools.
- **Teacher training institutions** may use the findings to improve pre-service and in-service courses, especially in learner-centred teaching and competency-based assessment.
- **Head teachers and Boards of Management** may use them to plan school-based professional development, peer support and instructional supervision.
- **Teachers** will get a clearer idea of their own strengths and weaknesses and of the kind of support that helps.

- **Researchers and scholars** will have evidence from a region that is seldom studied, and a starting point for further work on curriculum reform in marginalised settings.

1.9 Limitations of the Study

Some teachers may not want to admit gaps in their competence for fear that the information could be used against them. To deal with this, the questionnaire will be anonymous and respondents will be told clearly that the study has nothing to do with TSC appraisal. What teachers report will also be checked against classroom observation and school documents. Reaching remote schools may be difficult because the sub-county is large, the roads are poor and some areas are insecure. The researcher will plan travel together with the Sub-County Director of Education and the local administration, and will try to visit during the dry season. Pastoralist movement may also lower attendance on some observation days. Where a class is too small to reflect normal teaching, the observation will be rescheduled.

1.10 Delimitations of the Study

The study will cover only public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County. Private schools, pre-primary centres and junior schools are left out because they are staffed and managed differently. The respondents will be teachers of Grades 1 to 6 and head teachers. Teacher competence will be limited to two dimensions, namely knowledge and understanding of the CBC and pedagogical competence, and effective implementation will be judged using classroom-level indicators. Data collection will take place between March and April 2027.

1.11 Assumptions of the Study

The study assumes that respondents will give honest answers, that the records at the Sub-County Director of Education's office give a true picture of the number of schools and teachers, that the sampled schools will be safe and accessible during data collection, and that the lessons observed will reflect how teachers usually teach.

CHAPTER TWO LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

This chapter looks at what earlier researchers have found on teacher competence and the implementation of competency-based curricula. It first discusses the two theories on which the study is based and then reviews empirical studies under each of the four

objectives. The conceptual framework, a critique of the literature and a summary of the research gaps come at the end.

2.2 Theoretical Review

2.2.1 *Concerns-Based Adoption Model*

The Concerns-Based Adoption Model (CBAM) was developed at the University of Texas in the 1970s and is explained in detail by Hall and Hord (2020). It rests on the idea that change is a process and not a one-time event, and that it is individuals, rather than institutions, who change first. The model uses three diagnostic tools. The *Stages of Concern* trace how a teacher's worries shift when meeting an innovation. At first the teacher simply wants information; later come personal concerns ("What does this mean for me?") and management concerns ("Where will I get the time and materials?"); and only later does attention turn to the effect on learners and to working with colleagues to improve things. The *Levels of Use* describe what teachers actually do, ranging from non-use and mechanical use to routine and refined use. *Innovation Configurations* describe the different shapes an innovation takes once it reaches classrooms, some close to the original design and others far from it.

CBAM is relevant here because the CBC is an innovation that teachers in Habaswein have adopted to different degrees. A teacher whose only exposure to the CBC was a short workshop is likely to remain at the stage of personal or management concerns and to use the curriculum mechanically. The model therefore helps to explain why knowledge and understanding of the CBC (Objective 1) matter, since without them teachers cannot move past these early concerns. It also shows why contextual factors such as training, resources and support from head teachers (Objective 3) shape competence: each of them can either ease teachers' concerns or make them worse. One criticism of CBAM is that it concentrates on the individual teacher and pays less attention to wider structural issues such as policy changes or insecurity (Hall & Hord, 2020). This study tries to make up for that weakness by including contextual factors in its framework.

2.2.2 *Theory of Pedagogical Content Knowledge*

According to Shulman (1986), good teaching requires more than mastery of a subject, and more than knowledge of general teaching methods. It depends on a particular mix of the two, which he called pedagogical content knowledge (PCK). PCK is knowing how to present a given topic so that a given group of learners can understand it: which examples and activities work, and where learners usually get confused. Shulman's work later gave rise to wider frameworks such as technological pedagogical content knowledge, which adds the effective use of technology.

PCK applies to the CBC because the new curriculum changes not only the content taught but also the way it is taught and assessed. A teacher may know a learning area very well and still be unable to turn that content into an inquiry activity, a project or an authentic assessment task. The theory therefore supports Objective 2, which looks at pedagogical competence, and Objective 4, which links competence to implementation. In simple terms, the stronger a teacher's PCK, the closer the lesson is likely to be to what the curriculum developers had in mind. A weakness of the theory is that PCK cannot easily be observed, and teachers tend to rate themselves higher than they should. This is why the study will combine questionnaires with classroom observation and a review of lesson plans and assessment records.

2.3 Empirical Review

2.3.1 Teachers' Knowledge and Understanding of the Competency-Based Curriculum

Teachers cannot implement what they do not understand, and the available studies show that understanding of the CBC is uneven. In Rwanda, Nsengimana et al. (2023) interviewed twelve science teachers from three secondary schools eight years after the competence-based curriculum was introduced. Most of them could give the general reasons for the reform, but their idea of what a "competence" is, and how it differs from knowledge, was shallow. The study was small and qualitative, but it makes an important point: understanding does not simply come with time.

Locally, Momanyi and Rop (2019) used Stufflebeam's CIPP evaluation model to survey early grade teachers in Bomet East Sub-County. Most had only a vague grasp of CBC concepts, and this affected how they implemented the curriculum. Mwang'ombe (2021) came to a similar conclusion in a broader review: many teachers could list the core competencies but could not explain how to develop them during a lesson. In a more recent study of public primary schools in Kinangop Sub-County, Karua et al. (2025) found that awareness of CBC principles had improved, but teachers were slower in adjusting their teaching and learning approaches to match them. Keter and Wabuke (2025) studied junior school teachers in Bomet County and found that preparedness, including knowledge of CBC requirements, was closely related to how well the curriculum was implemented.

A common thread in these studies is the difference between knowing about the CBC and understanding it well enough to apply it. However, they were all carried out in areas with fairly good access to training and support. None of them focused on teachers in the arid north-east, where many are newly recruited, on contract, or trained

before the CBC. The current study will measure knowledge and understanding in that setting.

2.3.2 Teachers' Pedagogical Competence in Implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum

It is in pedagogy that understanding either becomes practice or fails to. APHRC (2022) observed CBC lessons in several Kenyan counties. Some teachers ran lively, learner-centred lessons, while many others still depended on chalk-and-talk and whole-class repetition. What separated the stronger lessons from the weaker ones was not so much resources as the teacher's skill in planning activities, asking open questions and getting learners involved.

Assessment keeps coming up as a problem area. Using observation and a review of earlier studies on junior schools, Cheruiyot (2024) found that many teachers were unsure how to conduct formative and school-based assessment. They kept learner portfolios mainly because they were required to, not because the portfolios informed their teaching. In public primary schools in Nairobi City, Awiti (2023) found that teachers' skill in learner-centred approaches and assessment had a strong effect on implementation, although large classes made individual assessment very difficult. In a survey of 351 teachers, Murithi and Yoo (2021) found that teachers were positive about using ICT in the CBC, but poor facilities and limited technical skills meant they rarely used it.

Findings from Uganda are similar. Kidega et al. (2024) reported that teachers in Gulu City often went back to lecturing because they had not been trained in the new methods and their classes were very large. On the whole, the literature suggests that pedagogical competence, particularly in learner-centred methods and assessment, is where teachers need the most help. Most of these studies, however, depended on questionnaires alone, and only a few compared what teachers said with what they did in class. This study will use both sources in a setting where no such evidence exists yet.

2.3.3 Factors Affecting Teachers' Competence in Implementing the Competency-Based Curriculum

Training is the factor mentioned most often. Kailo and Njagi (2025) looked at in-service training in public primary schools in Kilifi County and found that the quality of training resources and materials had a significant effect on how well teachers implemented the CBC. Many teachers considered the short cascade workshops, where a few are trained and expected to train the rest, to be inadequate. Evidence from other countries agrees. Professional development changes practice when it is continuous,

practical and tied to what teachers do in their own classrooms, not when it is a one-off event (Darling-Hammond et al., 2017; Guskey, 2002).

Resources and workload follow closely. Mogere (2022) found that teacher preparedness and the availability of teaching materials were the strongest determinants of CBC implementation in Nairobi County. In Machakos, Mutua and Waweru (2023) identified a shortage of learning materials and high teacher–pupil ratios as the main constraints. Akala (2021) argues that the CBC was introduced before schools had the people and materials it needed, which left teachers to improvise.

The local context also plays a part. Hussein (2023) studied CBC implementation in northern Kenya using 45 primary school teachers and 15 head teachers. Teachers struggled with the new subject divisions, teaching strategies and assessment techniques, and limited training and materials made matters worse. The staffing crisis in the north-east after 2023 has added a further problem. As many experienced non-local teachers left because of insecurity, schools in Wajir, Mandera and Garissa lost much of the CBC experience they had built up, and the TSC resorted to contract teachers to keep classes going (The Star, 2024). No study so far has examined how insecurity and staff turnover affect teachers' CBC competence. This study will look at these factors together with the more familiar ones of training, resources, workload and instructional support.

2.3.4 Teachers' Competence and Effective Implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum

A number of studies have measured the link between teacher competence and implementation directly. In a study of 79 public primary schools in Machakos County, Mutua and Waweru (2023) found that teachers' competence, measured by their knowledge, skills and attitudes, was associated with the level of CBC implementation. Keter and Wabuke (2025) used questionnaires, interviews and observation checklists in Bomet County and found a positive relationship between teacher preparedness and CBC implementation in junior schools. Similarly, Awiti (2023) found that teacher-related factors such as training and pedagogical skill accounted for much of the variation in implementation in Nairobi.

The general pattern is that implementation is stronger where teachers are more competent. The problem is that these studies were done almost entirely in counties with better infrastructure, denser populations and more stable staffing than Habaswein. It would be unwise to assume that the relationship is the same, or equally strong, where resources are scarcer and turnover higher. Shortages might be so severe

that even competent teachers cannot implement the CBC well. On the other hand, competence might matter even more because teachers have fewer materials to rely on. Testing the relationship in Habaswein will therefore add new knowledge.

2.4 Conceptual Framework

Figure 2.1 presents the conceptual framework, which shows the expected relationship between the variables. Teacher competence is the independent variable, measured through knowledge and understanding of the CBC and through pedagogical competence. The dependent variable is effective implementation of the CBC, indicated by learner engagement, integration of core competencies and values, continuous assessment, parental involvement and timely coverage of the curriculum designs. Factors such as training, resources, workload and class size, instructional support and insecurity are treated as intervening variables. These factors influence how competent teachers become, and they may also strengthen or weaken the effect of competence on implementation.

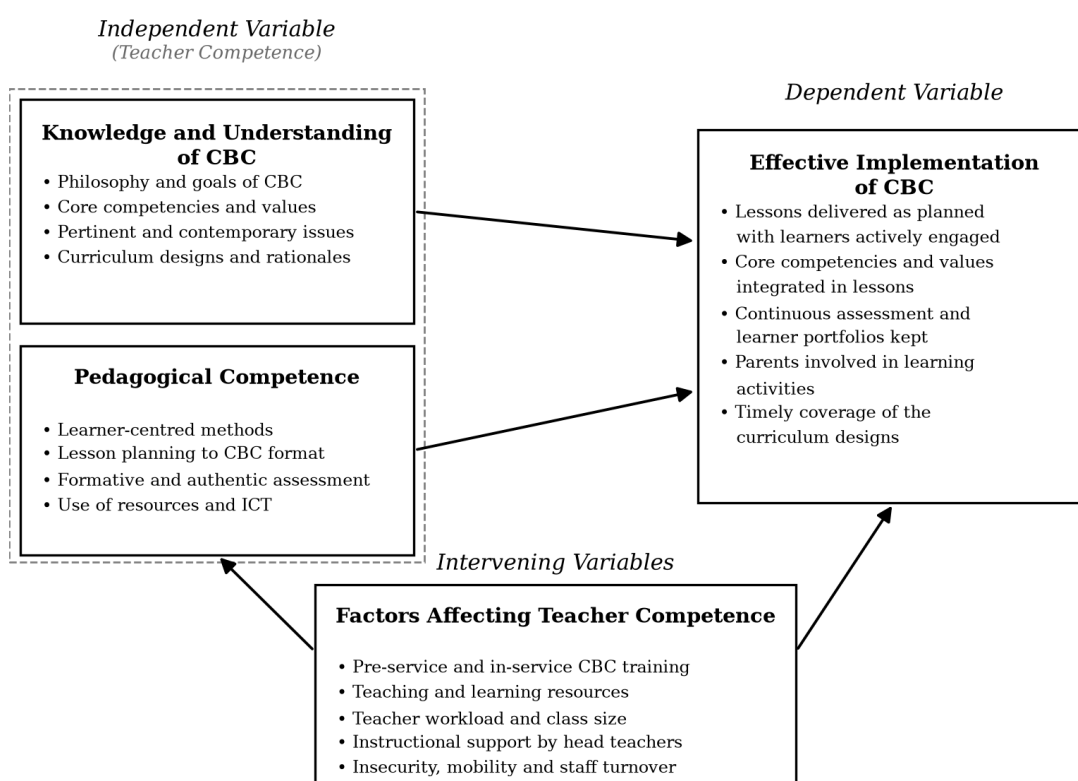


Figure 2.1: Conceptual Framework

2.5 Critique of Existing Literature

While the reviewed studies agree that teacher competence matters, they have four main shortcomings. The first is geographical. Most Kenyan studies were done in Nairobi, Machakos, Bomet, Nyandarua, Kilifi and other counties with fairly good

access to training and supervision, while the north-east appears mostly in commentaries and small descriptive studies such as Hussein (2023). The second is that many studies rely mainly on teachers' own reports, which tend to exaggerate competence. Only a few (APHRC, 2022; Keter & Wabuke, 2025) combined questionnaires with classroom observation. Thirdly, some studies treat "preparedness" or "training" as if they meant the same thing as competence, yet a teacher can attend training and still lack the skills to apply it. Lastly, most of the studies were done before the staffing disruption in the north-east after 2023 and the policy changes that followed the PWPER report, so they say nothing about the effect of these recent developments. The present study addresses these gaps by focusing on Habaswein, measuring two dimensions of competence directly, checking self-reports against observation and documents, and including insecurity and staff turnover among the factors studied.

2.6 Summary of Literature and Research Gaps

In summary, the review shows that teachers often understand the CBC only superficially and that their pedagogical competence, especially in learner-centred methods and assessment, varies widely. Training, resources, workload and context all shape this competence, and more competent teachers generally implement the CBC better. Table 2.1 summarises the main studies and the gaps they leave.

Table 2.1: Summary of Research Gaps

Author(s) and Year	Focus of Study	Key Findings	Research Gap
Momanyi and Rop (2019)	Teacher preparedness for CBC, Bomet East	Teachers' knowledge of CBC was vague and hindered implementation	Early grades only; conducted in a high-potential area
Mutua and Waweru (2023)	Teacher competence and CBC implementation, Machakos	Competence linked to implementation; materials and class size major constraints	Setting differs from arid, insecure north-east
Hussein (2023)	Challenges of CBC in northern Kenya	Weak training, few resources and difficulty with new methods	Small sample; descriptive; relationship not tested
Cheruiyot (2024)	Challenges of CBC in junior schools	Inadequate training; teachers unsure of assessment	Qualitative; junior schools; not region-specific
Kidega et al. (2024)	Teacher challenges with CBC in Gulu, Uganda	Large classes and poor training pushed teachers back to lecturing	Different country and level

Author(s) and Year	Focus of Study	Key Findings	Research Gap
Karua et al. (2025)	Teacher preparedness, Kinangop	Awareness improved but pedagogy not aligned to CBC	Relatively well-resourced area
Keter and Wabuke (2025)	Preparedness and CBC implementation, Bomet JSS	Positive relationship between preparedness and implementation	Junior schools; not marginalised setting
Kailo and Njagi (2025)	In-service training and CBC, Kilifi	Training materials significantly influenced implementation	Training only; other factors not examined

These gaps show the need for a study that measures teacher competence directly in a marginalised and insecure area and tests how it relates to CBC implementation. The present study in Habaswein Sub-County has been designed with this in mind.

CHAPTER THREE

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter describes how the study will be conducted. It presents the research design, study location, target population, sampling techniques and sample size, research instruments, piloting, validity and reliability, data collection procedures, data analysis and ethical considerations.

3.2 Research Design

A descriptive survey design with a mixed methods approach will be used. This design makes it possible to collect data from a fairly large number of respondents at one point in time and to describe things as they are, without manipulating any variable (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). It is therefore suitable for establishing the current level of teacher competence and how it relates to CBC implementation. Quantitative data from the teacher questionnaire will be used to measure competence and implementation and to test the relationship between the two. Qualitative data from head teacher interviews, lesson observation and document analysis will give more depth and help explain the numbers. Both kinds of data will be collected at the same time and brought together during interpretation, in line with a convergent approach (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). Mugenda and Mugenda (2003) observe that this design is common in Kenyan educational research because it offers both breadth and a close look at practice.

3.3 Location of the Study

The study will be conducted in Habaswein Sub-County, one of the sub-counties of Wajir County in north-eastern Kenya. The sub-county is in the south-western part of the county along the Garissa–Wajir road, and Habaswein town is its administrative headquarters. At the 2019 census it had a population of about 174,000 (KNBS, 2019). The climate is hot and dry. Most households keep livestock, although more and more families are settling around trading centres. Schools vary from fairly large ones in Habaswein town to small, remote schools that serve pastoralist communities.

Habaswein was selected for three reasons. It is a good example of the marginalised settings that are rarely included in CBC research. It was also directly affected when non-local teachers left the region after 2023 (The Star, 2024), which makes the question of teacher competence especially urgent. In addition, the researcher knows the area and its schools well, and this will make access easier and help in interpreting the findings.

3.4 Target Population

The target population is all teachers and head teachers in public primary schools in Habaswein Sub-County. Working figures indicate about 46 public primary schools with roughly 368 teachers and 46 head teachers. The researcher will confirm these figures with the Office of the Sub-County Director of Education before sampling. For sampling, the schools are placed in three strata that reflect the main settings in the sub-county: schools in Habaswein town and its surroundings, schools in rural settled areas, and remote schools that mainly serve pastoralist communities. The distribution is shown in Table 3.1.

Table 3.1: Target Population

Stratum	Number of Schools	Number of Teachers	Number of Head Teachers
Habaswein town and environs	10	124	10
Rural settled schools	20	164	20
Remote / pastoralist schools	16	80	16
Total	46	368	46

3.5 Sampling Techniques and Sample Size

3.5.1 Sampling Techniques

Teachers will be selected through proportionate stratified random sampling. Stratifying ensures that teachers in town, rural and remote schools are represented

according to their numbers, which is important because working conditions in these settings differ widely. In each stratum, teachers will be listed school by school and chosen by simple random sampling using a table of random numbers. Head teachers will be chosen through stratified purposive sampling. In each stratum, the researcher will pick head teachers of schools of different sizes and staffing levels so that the interviews capture a range of experiences. Classroom observation and document analysis will be done in the same 14 schools whose head teachers are interviewed.

3.5.2 Sample Size

Yamane's (1967) formula was used to work out the teacher sample at a 95% confidence level and a 5% margin of error:

$$n = N / (1 + N(e)^2)$$

Here n is the sample size, N is the target population of teachers (368) and e is the margin of error (0.05). Substituting these values gives:

$$n = 368 / (1 + 368 \times 0.0025) = 368 / 1.92 = 191.7 \approx 192 \text{ teachers}$$

The 192 teachers will be spread across the three strata according to their size, as Table 3.2 shows. For head teachers, 14 will be selected. This is about 30% of the 46 head teachers and falls within the 10% to 30% range that Mugenda and Mugenda (2003) regard as adequate for descriptive studies.

Table 3.2: Sample Size Distribution of Teachers

Stratum	Number of Teachers	Proportion	Sample Size
Habaswein town and environs	124	0.337	65
Rural settled schools	164	0.446	86
Remote / pastoralist schools	80	0.217	41
Total	368	1.000	192

Table 3.3: Summary of Sample Size

Category	Target Population	Sample Size	Sampling Technique
Teachers	368	192	Proportionate stratified random
Head teachers	46	14	Stratified purposive
Total	414	206	

Besides this, 28 lessons will be observed, two in each of the 14 schools, and the lesson plans, schemes of work, learner portfolios and assessment records in those schools will be reviewed.

3.6 Research Instruments

The study will use four instruments so that information from one source can be checked against the others.

Teacher questionnaire. The 192 teachers will fill in a structured questionnaire with six sections: background information, knowledge and understanding of the CBC, pedagogical competence, factors affecting competence, implementation of the CBC, and an open section for suggestions. Most items are on a five-point Likert scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Since English is the teachers' working language, the questionnaire will be in English. It should take about 25 minutes to complete.

Interview guide for head teachers. A semi-structured guide will be used to interview the 14 head teachers. The questions cover how teachers were prepared for the CBC, what support the school offers, the main problems teachers face and the head teacher's opinion on how well the CBC is being implemented. Each interview should last 30 to 45 minutes.

Classroom observation checklist. The researcher will observe 28 lessons using a checklist drawn from the CBC lesson structure. The checklist notes whether the lesson has clear learning outcomes and key inquiry questions, how learners take part, whether core competencies, values and pertinent and contemporary issues are brought in, how assessment is done and how resources are used. Every item is rated on a three-point scale: not observed, partly observed or fully observed.

Document analysis guide. The researcher will review schemes of work, lesson plans, learner portfolios, assessment records and in-service training records to confirm what teachers report and what is seen in class.

Table 3.4: Operationalisation of Study Variables

Variable	Type	Indicators	Measurement	Tool
Knowledge and understanding of CBC	Independent	Philosophy and goals; core competencies and values; PCIs; curriculum designs	Five-point Likert scale	Questionnaire; interview

Variable	Type	Indicators	Measurement	Tool
Pedagogical competence	Independent	Learner-centred methods; lesson planning; formative assessment; use of resources and ICT	Five-point Likert scale; three-point observation scale	Questionnaire; observation; documents
Factors affecting competence	Intervening	Training; resources; workload and class size; instructional support; insecurity and turnover	Five-point Likert scale; themes	Questionnaire; interview
Effective implementation of CBC	Dependent	Learner engagement; integration of competencies and values; continuous assessment; parental involvement; curriculum coverage	Five-point Likert scale; three-point observation scale	Questionnaire; observation; documents

3.7 Pilot Testing

The instruments will be piloted before the main study in public primary schools in Wajir South Sub-County. This sub-county borders Habaswein and has similar conditions, but it will not form part of the main sample. The pilot will involve 19 teachers (about 10% of the teacher sample) and two head teachers, following the guidance of Mugenda and Mugenda (2003), plus two lesson observations. It will help to identify unclear questions, find out how long the questionnaire takes, test whether the observation checklist is practical and check the reliability of the scales. The instruments will then be revised based on what the pilot reveals.

3.7.1 Validity of Research Instruments

Validity is the extent to which an instrument measures what it is supposed to measure (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). To ensure content validity, each item will be linked to a study objective and to the conceptual framework. The university supervisors and two curriculum studies experts will then go through the instruments and rate the relevance of every item. Their ratings will be used to compute a Content Validity Index (CVI), and a value of 0.80 or higher will be considered acceptable. The pilot will also help to confirm face validity by showing whether teachers understand the items as intended.

3.7.2 Reliability of Research Instruments

Reliability refers to how consistently an instrument produces the same results under similar conditions (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). Using the pilot data, Cronbach's alpha will be computed for each Likert scale in the questionnaire. A coefficient of

0.70 or more will be accepted, and any item that lowers a scale below this level will be reworded or removed. For the observation checklist, the researcher and a trained research assistant will each rate the two pilot lessons separately and then compare their scores. The trustworthiness of the qualitative data will be supported through triangulation of sources, detailed field notes, recording of interviews where consent is given and a clear record of the decisions made during analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

3.8 Data Collection Procedures

Once the proposal is approved, the researcher will get an introduction letter from Mount Kenya University, ethical clearance from the university's ethics review committee and a research permit from the National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation (NACOSTI). Permission will then be requested from the Wajir County Director of Education, the TSC Sub-County Director, the Sub-County Director of Education in Habaswein and the local administration. The head teachers of the sampled schools will be contacted early to agree on dates for the visits.

Three research assistants who know the area will be recruited and trained for two days on the instruments, the sampling procedure and research ethics. The questionnaires will be delivered in person and, where possible, collected the same day to keep the response rate high. The researcher will conduct all the head teacher interviews and lesson observations personally, and a research assistant will co-observe some lessons to check consistency. Documents will be reviewed during the school visit. Data will be collected in March and April 2027, and trips to remote schools will be planned with the advice of local security officers.

3.9 Data Analysis and Presentation

The completed questionnaires will be checked, coded and entered into the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) version 29. Objectives 1, 2 and 3 will be analysed using descriptive statistics, that is, frequencies, percentages, means and standard deviations. Means will be interpreted on the five-point scale, where 4.0 and above shows high competence, 3.0 to 3.9 moderate competence and below 3.0 low competence. For Objective 4, Pearson's product-moment correlation will be used to find the strength and direction of the relationship between teacher competence and CBC implementation, and simple linear regression will then be used to test the null hypothesis:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X + \varepsilon$$

In this model, Y stands for effective CBC implementation, β_0 is the constant, β_1 is the coefficient of teacher competence, X is the composite teacher competence score and ε is the error term. A multiple regression model will also be run to find out how much each dimension of competence contributes on its own:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_1 + \beta_2 X_2 + \varepsilon$$

X_1 represents knowledge and understanding of the CBC and X_2 represents pedagogical competence. The assumptions of normality, linearity, homoscedasticity and no multicollinearity will be tested before the regressions are run. The null hypothesis will be rejected where the p-value is below 0.05.

Interview recordings, observation notes and document reviews will be transcribed and read through several times. They will then be analysed thematically using the six phases set out by Braun and Clarke (2022): getting familiar with the data, coding, generating themes, reviewing them, defining and naming them, and writing up. Ratings from the observation checklist will be summarised using frequencies and percentages. Quantitative results will be presented in tables and charts, and qualitative results as themes backed by short quotations. The two sets of results will then be compared and discussed side by side. Table 3.5 gives a summary of the analysis plan.

Table 3.5: Summary of Data Analysis by Objective

Objective	Data Source	Method of Analysis
1. Knowledge and understanding of CBC	Questionnaire; interviews	Frequencies, percentages, means, standard deviations; thematic analysis
2. Pedagogical competence	Questionnaire; observation; documents	Frequencies, percentages, means, standard deviations; thematic analysis
3. Factors affecting competence	Questionnaire; interviews	Frequencies, percentages, means; thematic analysis
4. Relationship between competence and implementation	Questionnaire; observation	Pearson's correlation; simple and multiple linear regression

Source: Researcher (2026)

3.10 Ethical Considerations

The study will observe the ethical standards expected in research involving people. No data will be collected before approval from the Mount Kenya University ethics review committee and a NACOSTI research permit have been obtained. Participation will be voluntary. Before signing the consent form, each respondent will be told the

purpose of the study, what taking part involves and any possible risks, and will be free to skip any question or withdraw at any point without penalty. Names will not appear on questionnaires, and schools will be identified by codes in the report. Respondents will be assured that the study is independent of the TSC and that nothing they say will be used for appraisal or discipline. Lesson observations will be arranged beforehand with the teacher's consent, and the researcher will take care not to disrupt teaching. Interviews will be recorded only if the respondent agrees. Electronic data will be kept on a password-protected computer and paper forms in a locked cabinet, and all raw data will be destroyed five years after the study. The researcher will also respect local customs, for example by planning visits around prayer times and working with community leaders. All sources will be acknowledged, and the findings will be shared with the Sub-County Director of Education and the participating schools.

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APPENDICES

Appendix I: Letter of Introduction

[Student Name]

Mount Kenya University, School of Education

P.O. Box 342-01000, Thika

Dear Respondent,

RE: REQUEST TO PARTICIPATE IN A RESEARCH STUDY

I am a Master of Education student at Mount Kenya University, School of Education. As part of the requirements for the degree, I am carrying out a study titled “Assessing Teachers’ Competence and its Influence on the Effective Implementation of the Competency-Based Curriculum in Public Primary Schools in Habaswein Sub-County, Wajir County, Kenya”.

Your school is one of those selected for the study, and I kindly ask you to spare some time to fill in the questionnaire or take part in an interview. There are no right or wrong answers; I am only interested in your honest views and experience. Whatever you share will be kept confidential and used for academic purposes only. The study is not connected to the TSC in any way and will not be used for appraisal, and your name will not appear anywhere in the report.

Thank you for your time and cooperation.

Yours faithfully,

MOHAMED ABDI IBRAHIM

Reg. No. MED20243116

Appendix II: Informed Consent Form

I have been informed of the purpose of this study, what taking part involves, and my right to decline to answer any question or to withdraw at any time without any consequence. I understand that my responses will be kept confidential and used only for academic purposes, and that the study is not linked to TSC appraisal. I therefore voluntarily agree to take part in this study.

Signature of respondent: _____ Date: _____

Signature of researcher: _____ Date: _____

Appendix III: Questionnaire for Teachers

Instructions: Please tick (✓) the appropriate box or write your answer in the space provided. Do not write your name or the name of your school on this questionnaire.

Section A: Background Information

1. Gender: Male [] Female []
2. Age (years): Below 30 [] 30–39 [] 40–49 [] 50 and above []
3. Highest professional qualification: P1 Certificate [] Diploma [] Degree [] Postgraduate []
4. Teaching experience (years): Below 3 [] 3–5 [] 6–10 [] Above 10 []
5. Terms of service: TSC permanent [] TSC contract [] BOM []
6. Grades you currently teach: Grades 1–3 [] Grades 4–6 [] Both []
7. Number of CBC trainings attended: None [] 1 [] 2–3 [] 4 or more []
8. Location of your school: Habaswein town [] Rural settled [] Remote / pastoralist []
9. Approximate number of learners in your largest class: Below 40 [] 40–60 [] 61–80 [] Above 80 []

Section B: Knowledge and Understanding of the CBC

Key: SD = Strongly Disagree (1); D = Disagree (2); N = Neutral (3); A = Agree (4); SA = Strongly Agree (5)

No.	Statement	SD	D	N	A	SA
10	I understand the vision and mission of the Competency-Based Curriculum.					
11	I can explain the difference between the CBC and the 8-4-4 curriculum.					
12	I can name and explain the seven core competencies of the CBC.					
13	I understand how to integrate values into my lessons.					
14	I understand how to integrate pertinent and contemporary issues into my lessons.					
15	I understand how to use the curriculum designs for the learning areas I teach.					
16	I understand the role of parents in the CBC.					

Section C: Pedagogical Competence

Key: SD = Strongly Disagree (1); D = Disagree (2); N = Neutral (3); A = Agree (4); SA = Strongly Agree (5)

No.	Statement	SD	D	N	A	SA
17	I prepare lesson plans with clear specific learning outcomes and key inquiry questions.					
18	I use learner-centred methods such as group work, projects and discussion in most lessons.					
19	I give learners opportunities to apply what they learn to real-life situations.					
20	I use a variety of formative assessment methods (observation, oral questions, projects, portfolios).					
21	I keep up-to-date assessment records and learner portfolios.					
22	I use feedback from assessment to adjust my teaching.					
23	I improvise teaching and learning resources from the local environment.					
24	I use ICT devices in teaching where they are available.					

Section D: Factors Affecting Teacher Competence

Key: SD = Strongly Disagree (1); D = Disagree (2); N = Neutral (3); A = Agree (4); SA = Strongly Agree (5)

No.	Statement	SD	D	N	A	SA
25	The CBC training I have received was adequate for my needs.					
26	I have regular opportunities for CBC professional development.					
27	My school has adequate textbooks and teaching materials for the CBC.					
28	My teaching workload allows me enough time to plan CBC lessons.					
29	Large class sizes make it difficult to use learner-centred methods and assessment.					
30	The head teacher and curriculum support officers support me in implementing the CBC.					
31	Insecurity in the area affects teaching and learning in my school.					
32	The departure of teachers from my school has affected CBC implementation.					
33	Pastoralist mobility and learner absenteeism make continuous assessment difficult.					

Section E: Implementation of the CBC

Key: SD = Strongly Disagree (1); D = Disagree (2); N = Neutral (3); A = Agree (4); SA = Strongly Agree (5)

No.	Statement	SD	D	N	A	SA
34	Learners in my classes actively take part in learning activities.					
35	Core competencies and values are integrated in the lessons I teach.					
36	I carry out continuous assessment as required by the CBC.					
37	Learners complete projects and practical activities as required.					
38	Parents are involved in their children's learning activities.					
39	I cover the curriculum designs within the planned time.					
40	Overall, the CBC is being implemented effectively in my school.					

Section F: General Comments

41. What would most help you to implement the CBC more effectively in your school?

.....

.....

.....

Thank you for your participation.

Appendix IV: Interview Guide for Head Teachers

Introduction: The researcher will introduce themselves, explain the purpose of the study, assure the head teacher of confidentiality, and seek consent to take notes and record the interview.

1. How long have you been head teacher in this school, and how many teachers do you have? How many are on contract or BOM terms?
2. How were teachers in this school prepared for the CBC? What training have they received, and how useful was it?
3. How would you describe your teachers' understanding of the CBC? Where are the main gaps?

4. How confident are your teachers in lesson planning, learner-centred methods and competency-based assessment?
5. What support do you, the curriculum support officers and the TSC give teachers in implementing the CBC?
6. What challenges affect your teachers' competence? How have resources, workload, class size, insecurity and staff turnover affected the school?
7. In your view, how well is the CBC being implemented in this school? Can you give an example of good practice, and of where things fall short?
8. Do you see a difference in how the CBC is implemented by teachers with more training or experience compared with others?
9. What should the Ministry of Education, the TSC and KICD do to strengthen teachers' competence in areas like Habaswein?

Appendix V: Classroom Observation Checklist

School code: _____ Grade: _____ Learning area: _____ Date: _____
 Number of learners present: _____

Key: 0 = Not observed; 1 = Partly observed; 2 = Fully observed

No.	Aspect Observed	0	1	2	Remarks
1	Lesson plan has specific learning outcomes and key inquiry questions				
2	Lesson introduction links to learners' prior knowledge and experience				
3	Learner-centred activities (group work, discussion, practical tasks) are used				
4	Most learners actively take part in the lesson				
5	At least one core competency is deliberately developed				
6	Values and/or pertinent and contemporary issues are integrated				
7	Teaching and learning resources, including improvised ones, are used				
8	ICT is used where available				
9	Formative assessment is carried out during the lesson				
10	Teacher gives learners feedback on their work				
11	Lesson concludes with reflection or a link to real life				

No.	Aspect Observed	0	1	2	Remarks
12	Learners are given a community service or home-based activity involving parents				

Appendix VI: Document Analysis Guide

Document	Available (Yes/No)	Up to Date (Yes/No)	Remarks on Quality
Schemes of work based on curriculum designs			
Lesson plans			
Learner portfolios			
Formative / school-based assessment records			
Records of CBC training and professional development			
Inventory of CBC textbooks and teaching materials			
Records of instructional supervision by head teacher / CSO			
Teacher staffing records (including transfers since 2023)			

Appendix VII: Work Plan

Activity	Timeline
Development and approval of the research proposal	October – December 2026
Proposal defence and corrections	January 2027
Ethical clearance and NACOSTI research permit	February 2027
Pilot testing and refinement of instruments	February 2027
Field data collection	March – April 2027
Data analysis and interpretation	May 2027
Thesis writing and submission to supervisors	June – July 2027
Thesis defence, corrections and final submission	August 2027

Appendix VIII: Research Budget

Budget Item	Estimated Cost (KES)
Literature and reference materials	10,000
Printing and photocopying of instruments	12,000
Training and remuneration of 3 research assistants	36,000
Transport and security arrangements within Habaswein Sub-County	45,000

Budget Item	Estimated Cost (KES)
Accommodation and subsistence during fieldwork	30,000
Pilot study in Wajir South Sub-County	12,000
Communication and airtime	5,000
Data analysis software and services	15,000
Ethical review and NACOSTI permit fees	6,000
Thesis printing, binding and dissemination	12,000
Subtotal	183,000
Contingency (10%)	18,300
Total	201,300